Strixhaven: School of Mages Report: Learned Archetypes, Bombs, and Synergies

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Dataset Snapshot

This run uses 101,865 unique deck builds and 465,319 game rows. The unsupervised clustering stage produced 7 learned archetypes. The best-performing large shells are Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage, Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip, Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece, which already tells us that the format is not a single monolithic color table: it separates into distinct deck families with their own signposts, core cards, and build-around incentives.

1 Discovered Archetypes

Archetype	Decks	Games	WR	Top signposts
Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	10,589	53,107	60.02%	Owlin Shieldmage, Silverquill Pledgemage, Arrogant Poet, Combat Professor, Guiding Voice
Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	24,486	113,629	55.07%	Eureka Moment, Field Trip, Needlethorn Drake, Leyline Invocation, Scurrid Colony
Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	12,254	57,006	54.93%	Prismari Pledgemage, Elemental Masterpiece, Serpentine Curve, Spectacle Mage, Bury in Books
Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	10,285	46,161	54.38%	Spiteful Squad, Star Pupil, Promising Duskmage, Guiding Voice, Owlin Shieldmage
Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	15,229	67,238	53.67%	Illustrious Historian, Lorehold Pledgemage, Enthusiastic Study, Pilgrim of the Ages, Blood Age General
Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	17,740	79,157	53.01%	Hunt for Specimens, Blood Researcher, Witherbloom Pledgemage, Bayou Groff, Professor of Zoomancy

Archetype	Decks	Games	WR	Top signposts
Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	11,282	49,021	50.71%	`Spectacle Mage`, `Prismari Pledgemage`, `Elemental Masterpiece`, `Pigment Storm`, `Frost Trickster`

2 What Defines the Best Shells

Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage

This cluster contains 10,589 decks across 53,107 games and posts a baseline win rate of 60.02%. Its defining cards are `Owlin Shieldmage`, `Silverquill Pledgemage`, `Arrogant Poet`, `Combat Professor`, `Guiding Voice`, `Study Break`.

The strongest positive links in the shell are Leech Fanatic + Mascot Exhibition, Blot Out the Sky + Pilgrim of the Ages, Mavinda, Students' Advocate + Pilgrim of the Ages. The build-around detector flags `Rise of Extus`, `Pilgrim of the Ages`, `Spiteful Squad` as true support-dependent payoffs, while the shell-dependence score describes the broader class of cards that rely heavily on the surrounding shell.

Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip

This cluster contains 24,486 decks across 113,629 games and posts a baseline win rate of 55.07%. Its defining cards are `Eureka Moment`, `Field Trip`, `Needlethorn Drake`, `Leyline Invocation`, `Scurrid Colony`, `Mage Duel`.

The strongest positive links in the shell are Multiple Choice + Quandrix Apprentice, Multiple Choice + Zimone, Quandrix Prodigy, Needlethorn Drake + Zimone, Quandrix Prodigy. The build-around detector flags no high-confidence build-arounds as true support-dependent payoffs, while the shell-dependence score describes the broader class of cards that rely heavily on the surrounding shell.

Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece

This cluster contains 12,254 decks across 57,006 games and posts a baseline win rate of 54.93%. Its defining cards are `Prismari Pledgemage`, `Elemental Masterpiece`, `Serpentine Curve`, `Spectacle Mage`, `Bury in Books`, `Rootha, Mercurial Artist`.

The strongest positive links in the shell are Draconic Intervention + Expressive Iteration, Explosive Welcome + Expressive Iteration, Explosive Welcome + Fractal Summoning. The build-around detector flags `Pillardrop Warden` as true support-dependent payoffs, while the shell-dependence score describes the broader class of cards that rely heavily on the surrounding shell.

Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil

This cluster contains 10,285 decks across 46,161 games and posts a baseline win rate of 54.38%. Its defining cards are `Spiteful Squad`, `Star Pupil`, `Promising Duskmage`, `Guiding Voice`, `Owlin Shieldmage`, `Lash of Malice`.

The strongest positive links in the shell are Owlin Shieldmage + Poet's Quill, Pilgrim of the Ages + Rise of Extus, Guiding Voice + Mascot Exhibition. The build-around detector flags `Guiding Voice`, `Pillardrop Rescuer`, `Spiteful Squad` as true support-dependent payoffs, while the shell-dependence score describes the broader class of cards that rely heavily on the surrounding shell.

3 Bombs: Cards That Are Good Alone

Card	Best cluster	Standalone lift	Drawn-game WR	Games
`Mascot Exhibition`	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	16.67 pp	67.38%	794
`Lorehold Command`	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	13.79 pp	67.46%	2815
`Draconic Intervention`	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	13.12 pp	68.05%	2282
`Multiple Choice`	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	12.98 pp	63.70%	1391
`Shadrix Silverquill`	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	12.62 pp	67.00%	709
`Blot Out the Sky`	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	12.45 pp	66.83%	618
`Igneous Inspiration`	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	10.33 pp	65.26%	6759
`Expanded Anatomy`	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	9.24 pp	59.95%	4467
`Blade Historian`	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	9.22 pp	62.89%	2412
`Poet's Quill`	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	9.19 pp	62.20%	2127
`Fractal Summoning`	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	8.26 pp	63.20%	9681

Card	Best cluster	Standalone lift	Drawn-game WR	Games
Velomachus Lorehold	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	8.21 pp	63.28%	256

4 Build-Arounds and Shell Dependence

Card	Best cluster	Shell dependence	Support delta	Supported games
Rise of Extus	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	10.82 pp	8529
Pilgrim of the Ages	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	9.14 pp	8205
Pillardrop Warden	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	10.0 / 10	22.34 pp	10863
Guiding Voice	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	10.0 / 10	9.31 pp	7111
Pillardrop Rescuer	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	10.0 / 10	10.54 pp	4985
Illustrious Historian	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	12.91 pp	12401
Quintorius, Field Historian	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	14.75 pp	7639
Cram Session	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	10.0 / 10	10.80 pp	7781
Oggyar Battle-Seer	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	12.12 pp	4770
Spiteful Squad	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	9.8 / 10	6.96 pp	6821
Witherbloom Pledgemage	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	9.7 / 10	9.26 pp	14019
Tome Shredder	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	9.4 / 10	15.64 pp	6194

5 Dependency Cards

Card	Best cluster	Dependency	Standalone lift	Games
Cram Session	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	1.251	0.55 pp	7923
Elemental Summoning	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.732	4.61 pp	12948
Mortality Spear	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	0.703	4.27 pp	9254
Illustrious Historian	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.648	-1.52 pp	12732
Unwilling Ingredient	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	0.613	-3.89 pp	10088
Creative Outburst	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.491	6.23 pp	8626
Blot Out the Sky	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	0.450	10.34 pp	604
Mascot Exhibition	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	0.416	6.86 pp	631
Expressive Iteration	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.396	6.64 pp	7643
Mavinda, Students' Advocate	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	0.390	7.08 pp	544
Rise of Extus	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	0.316	4.87 pp	12339
Rootha, Mercurial Artist	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.276	3.13 pp	12804

6 Best Draft Priorities

Card	Best cluster	Pick score	Draft win lift	Rarity
Igneous Inspiration	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	3.48 pp	uncommon
Quandrix Cultivator	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	2.25 pp	uncommon

Card	Best cluster	Pick score	Draft win lift	Rarity
Elemental Summoning	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	0.75 pp	common
Bury in Books	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	1.16 pp	common
Fractal Summoning	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	0.24 pp	common
Inkling Summoning	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	10.0 / 10	0.96 pp	common
Lorehold Command	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	2.95 pp	rare
Devouring Tendrils	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	9.9 / 10	1.86 pp	uncommon
Mage Duel	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	9.8 / 10	0.91 pp	common
Expressive Iteration	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	9.8 / 10	1.70 pp	uncommon
Expanded Anatomy	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	10.0 / 10	1.13 pp	common
Heated Debate	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	9.8 / 10	1.20 pp	common

7 Most Striking Positive Pairs

Pair	Cluster	Quality	Pair WR	Games
Lorehold Command, Returned Pastcaller	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	1.64	75.22%	448
Draconic Intervention, Expressive Iteration	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	1.42	77.75%	427
Explosive Welcome, Expressive Iteration	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	1.31	70.76%	961
Leech Fanatic, Mascot Exhibition	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	1.13	75.76%	99
Blot Out the Sky, Pilgrim of the Ages	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	1.05	77.27%	110

Pair	Cluster	Quality	Pair WR	Games
Explosive Welcome, Fractal Summoning	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	1.05	71.12%	1122
Igneous Inspiration, Illustrious Historian	Boros Spirit | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	1.05	63.81%	1224
Mage Hunters' Onslaught, Mascot Exhibition	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	1.04	72.59%	197
Pigment Storm, Prismari Apprentice	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	1.04	61.70%	1616
Multiple Choice, Quandrix Apprentice	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	0.98	73.03%	508
Creative Outburst, Pillardrop Warden	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.94	64.63%	1985
Multiple Choice, Zimone, Quandrix Prodigy	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	0.91	72.56%	492
Bury in Books, Rootha, Mercurial Artist	Izzet Orc | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.88	65.45%	4287
Heated Debate, Rootha, Mercurial Artist	Izzet Bird | Spectacle Mage / Prismari Pledgemage	0.82	60.36%	2036

8 Anti-Synergies Worth Respecting

Pair	Cluster	Anti-score	Pair WR	Games
Exhilarating Elocution, Guiding Voice	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.77	43.41%	539
Exhilarating Elocution, Professor's Warning	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.77	41.79%	347
Exhilarating Elocution, Pillardrop Rescuer	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.75	41.37%	336
Essence Infusion, Promising Duskmage	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.58	44.17%	489
Leech Fanatic, Moldering Karok	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	0.50	45.64%	1720

Pair	Cluster	Anti-score	Pair WR	Games
Arrogant Poet, Silverquill Apprentice	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	0.48	49.56%	1029
Dina, Soul Steeper, Unwilling Ingredient	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	0.48	45.13%	1283
Eager First-Year, Humiliate	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.47	47.88%	472
Eager First-Year, Professor of Symbology	Orzhov Bird | Owlin Shieldmage / Silverquill Pledgemage	0.46	54.07%	712
Eager First-Year, Silverquill Pledgemage	Orzhov Humans | Spiteful Squad / Star Pupil	0.45	45.85%	698

9 Bottom-Line Reading

This report treats the format as a deck ecosystem rather than a flat card ranking. The strongest cards show up in the bomb table because they win on their own. The cards that pull a cluster together show up in the build-around and dependency tables because they need a shell. The pair and anti-synergy sections then explain which combinations reinforce a winning plan and which combinations look attractive in draft but underperform together.